

User Observation Record — Participant 1

Participant: P1

Date: October 6, 2026

System: Amazon

Session Type: Contextual observation

Primary Task: Find a specific product, narrow the search results using filters, and determine whether to purchase the product.

Approximate Session Length: 15 minutes

Task 1 — Search for a Product

Task given to participant:

"Find a pair of wireless headphones that you would consider purchasing."

Observations

The participant entered "wireless headphones" into the search bar. After the results loaded, they immediately began scrolling through the page rather than using the filters.

The participant stopped several times to look at different products. They appeared to have difficulty determining which results were sponsored advertisements and which were regular search results.

Participant quote:

"There's a lot going on here. I don't really know which one I should look at."

The participant eventually selected a product after scrolling through several results.

Pain Point

The large number of competing products, advertisements, ratings, prices, and shipping information created a high amount of visual and cognitive load.

Potential heuristic: Match Between the System and the Real World / Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Severity: 2 — Minor usability problem

Task 2 — Narrow the Results

Task given to participant:

"Use Amazon's filters to narrow the results to headphones within a price range you would normally consider."

Observations

The participant located the price filter but initially looked for a slider rather than manually entering a minimum and maximum price.

They paused before selecting the filter.

Participant quote:

"I thought there would be a slider here."

The participant entered a price range and continued browsing.

Pain Point

The participant's expectation of how the price filter would work did not match the interface they encountered.

Mental Model Mismatch:

The participant expected a visual range selector, while the interface required entering values.

Potential heuristic: Match Between the System and the Real World

Severity: 2 — Minor usability problem

Task 3 — Evaluate a Product

Task given to participant:

"Choose one product and determine whether you would purchase it."

Observations

The participant opened a product page and immediately began looking for the price and customer rating. They had to scroll before finding additional product information.

They spent several seconds looking through reviews and product information.

Participant quote:

"I would probably have to keep scrolling to figure out everything about this."

The participant ultimately said they would consider purchasing the product but wanted to compare it with another product first.

Pain Point

Important purchasing information was distributed throughout a long page, requiring the participant to scan and remember information while comparing products.

Potential heuristic: Recognition Rather Than Recall

Severity: 2 — Minor usability problem

Overall Participant Findings

The participant experienced the greatest difficulty with:

1. The large amount of information presented in search results.
2. Distinguishing sponsored results from other products.
3. Understanding how to use the price filter.
4. Locating all of the information necessary to make a purchasing decision.

Overall Participant Impression

The participant was able to complete the tasks without assistance, but frequently paused while determining where to look next. The main source of friction appeared to be the amount of information presented simultaneously rather than an inability to complete the tasks.